EXHIBITION

THOSE WERE **THE DAYS**

An ongoing exhibition highlights the role played by cinematographer **Josef Wirsching** in the evolution of Bombay Talkies



TURNING BACK TIME (Clockwise from the left) A view of the exhibition; shooting for the 1938 film *Nirmala*; a scene from *Jawani Ki Hawa* depicted in a 3D tableau at CSMVS, and a 1924 image of Josef Wirsching







We think the world is connected like never before now but, even a hundred years ago, there was an immense amount of sharing of ideas in a cultural convergence beyond borders. Actor Devika Rani, producer Himanshu Rai, director Franz Osten and cinematographer Josef Wirsching met in Munich, Germany, in the 1920s. Creativity sparked, and the result was the classic silent film, *Light of Asia* (1925), one of the first films entirely shot on location in India. Next came *Karma* (1933), which catapulted Devika to star status in the UK and also saw her romantic relationship with Rai strengthening. With opportunities in Europe limited by the climate of war at the time, Osten and Wirsching came to India to help Rai and Devika start a talkie film studio in Mumbai. Bombay Talkies, as their studio was named, produced some of the most iconic musical films of the time like *Jawani ki Hawa* (1935) and *Achhut Kanya* (1936). Wirsching, whose German Expressionist style of depicting inner turmoil can be seen in many films of the time, is a creative spirit whose name should be kept alive in the hearts of cinephiles. *A Cinematic Imagination: Josef Wirsching & the Bombay Talkies*, presented by the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Vastu Sangrahalaya (CSMVS), Mumbai, and the Jehangir Nicholson Art Foundation in collaboration with the Alkazi Foundation for the Arts, does just that, bringing the early era of innovation in pre-independent India and the path-breaking collaboration of Wirsching and this group of passionate filmmakers.

On view at CSMVS's Jehangir Nicholson gallery until April 17, it's a priceless collection of original black and white photographs and digital reprints from the Josef Wirsching Archive in Goa as well as letters, photocards and more from the Dietze Family Archive in Melbourne, Australia. The gorgeously mounted exhibition has been curated by Debashree Mukherjee and Rahaab Allana in collaboration with Georg and Josef (Jr) Wirsching.

At first glance, what the pictures portray are the early years of Indian cinema, transitioning between the silent era to the 'talkies'. Shot by Wirsching on 35mm with his Leica camera, the images offer telling glimpses of the filmmaking, creative processes, and the evocative exchanges between those whose decisions and experiences defined the path forward for Indian cinema as we know it today. An entire section dedicated to Devika is aptly titled 'the First lady of the Indian Screen'. The pivotal shot here is a stunning still from *Jawani Ki Hawa* that captures her gazing into the eyes of co-star Najmul-Hassan, her real-life paramour.

If you've been charmed by the OTT series *Jubilee* or entranced by the story told by the National Museum of Indian Cinema on Mumbai's Peddar Road, you'll love this exhibition, which brings alive that time of transition, the impact of geopolitics and world events on things hyperlocal, as well as human foibles and fancies, in the most evocative way. ■

–Priya Pathiyan